fascinating about these poems is their coverage of wider aspects of life and death and, in particular, observations of the natural world.

There is a delightful freshness and a muscular vigour to the *Purananuru* that makes them instantly accessible, nowhere more so than in the recent translations into English by the combined team of George L. Hart, Professor of Tamil Language at UC Berkeley, and Hank Heifetz, also a scholar of Tamil and an outstanding poet in his own right. One of the shortest poems, Poem 128, for example, is composed in honour of a king of the Ay dynasty, which was one of the major powers in the South before the rise of the Cheras, and whose descendants continued to rule parts of South India as vassal kings into the tenth century:

> *On Poti mountain, the realm of Ay who wears sliding bracelets,*
> *in the giant branches of the jack tree growing in his courtyard,*
> *a monkey, thinking it a fruit, beats on the clear sweet-singing*
> *eye of a drum left hanging there by some who travelled to him*
> *in their need and a wild goose calls out as if keeping time!*
> *Unless a woman will approach it dancing,*
> *Mighty kings have no hope of ever coming near that hill!*[19]

What is so striking about these works – indeed, quite remarkable in the Indian context – is their essentially secular nature. 'The *Purananuru*,' writes Professor Hart, 'is one of the few works of classical India that confronts life without the insulation of a philosophical façade; it makes no basic assumptions about *karma* and the other world; it faces existence as a great and unsolved mystery.'